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Chris & Dan Brubeck

Bassist and trombonist Chris Brubeck, and drummer Dan Brubeck keep their parents' legacy alive by touring with the Brubeck Brothers Quartet. They also lead their own ensembles, performing music that encompasses an eclectic mix of contemporary styles.

Chris and Dan were interviewed in Clinton, New York on February 19, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are at the morning after with Dan and Chris Brubeck, who played a marvelous concert in Wellin Hall at Hamilton College last night. I was enthralled by the interpretations of your father's music. The core of them were there but how do you decide to bring them alive so that they fit the way you play?

DB: I think you know certain things, I'll hear other ways to play something like for instance in "Kathy's Waltz," I've always heard that that could be a great kind of reggae-feeling thing, which you wouldn't think of right away but we tried it and it was like hey that actually works great. And I remember at the recording session Mike had worked out this whole opening thing and it was like, "Oh yeah, that works great but I'd really like to play a chordal guitar thing." And it was like, "Well do that in the beginning and then we'll go into it," which is how we wound up doing it. But a lot of times everyone's got their individual, like, ideas, and we just throw them out and you know with my dad's music I kind of know it inside out. So for years all that stuff rattles around and you hear it in different ways. And so many of his tunes I'll be practicing and I'll think oh you could do this with that, and I'll just approach it completely differently, slightly for my own sanity but you know also just because you can interpret things so many different ways and it's good because later you can use that even if you're not playing that particular style you can use that in terms of what you add to a piece, you know, how you approach it one night thing.

CB: The other thing just in general is that the pianist in our group, Chuck Lamb, and a guitarist, Mike DeMicco and Dan and I, it's a highly democratic process you know. So when we put out a record or when we do a concert, it is sort of like a Venn diagram of all the things that we happen to think is cool, probably much to our commercial demise you know, well in terms of like for example none of us wants to make a record that sounds anything like any Kenny G record. Sorry, Kenny. Or any of the hundreds of sax players that all sound the same to me that are sort of smooth jazz you know people or whatever. There's this thing that Chuck thinks is cool, Mike thinks is cool, we think it's cool, and that's narrowly where we go. But you know like when Dan was mentioning reggae, like

for “Kathy’s Waltz” it’s just interesting to think of when “Kathy’s Waltz” was written reggae didn’t even exist. You know? So because our dad went out to the Middle East and he incorporated music that didn’t exist in the United States like the Turkish beat that became “Blue Rondo” I feel like he sort of gave us the grand rights to explore and put other music into our re-interpretations of his music. If he were our age he’d be doing it. And the other thing is because of our age we all have a rock & roll kind of influence, even though we’re not playing rock & roll. Like I try to explain to people, like I said, “Well Dan is a really interesting drummer, I mean he’s quite amazing, but think if Keith Moon played jazz.” You know? Because there’s a different energy approach. And then Mike can do all the rock & roll stuff and Chuck is very percussive. So we all respect and like, you know, straight ahead bebop and all that kind of stuff. But we can’t change what’s crept into us culturally because of the age we are, and I know conversely in doing gigs with Dave and Gerry Mulligan and different people, they can’t authentically incorporate any of that rock & roll language into what they’re doing.

MR: Yeah, I’ve heard that like you’re still playing straight eighth notes. Like with the older fellas like in a big band. And you give them a rock number and they’re still swinging.

DB: Yeah, they all sound like Herman Munster.

CB: Not all. I mean there are some exceptions. But mainly I’m just acknowledging that each generation has their cultural influences that are in their blood.

MR: So you’re guitar, bass, drums, and keyboard can be a rhythm section for a big band but it’s also a band in itself. So within a quartet band if we call you two the rhythm section within that, who’s the boss in your rhythm section? Or is that not the way to put it?

CB: I think it’s totally democratic. I don’t think we look at each other as the boss. I mean I do say that I look at myself as the bass player as having the more responsibilities and less freedom, not that I would play any other way because culturally and aesthetically I grew up listening to Eugene Wright who had a real defined role in the Dave Brubeck Quartet. And you know there were other bass players in Gene’s era. Well first of all he came out of playing with Count Basie and stuff like that. So he was a real meat and potatoes bass player where part of the thing is like how thick are your fingers and how loud can you play and play well, which has nothing to do with, you know, on the extreme end of Scott LaFaro’s developing all this technique and all these other kind of bass players, and in my case, with an electric bass, like the whole Jaco Pastorius thing, you know, who was an incredible player and very, very technical and all the others that followed him, that was not my aesthetic. I mean I was already set in my ways before Jaco Pastorius appeared on the map. My ways were I’m playing in a group often times with my dad, he’s old school enough that he plays a lot of roots with his left hand, and when you’re the bass player in that group you either have to be with him or you’re wrong. Whereas if you were playing

with Herbie Hancock the left hand is open so the bass players have a lot more freedom to do different things because they won't be clashing with the left hand of the piano player because he's not playing roots anyhow. So you adjust to that kind of thing and the responsibilities of Gene are keep track of the chord progressions, keep it simple. I mean Joe, the chemistry of that group was incredible. Joe Morello couldn't have done all the beautiful things of flying away from core 4/4 without Gene taking the — well sort of the role and the sacrifice of I'm just going to, Dave always called it "holding the fort." I'm holding the fort, Dave, you're doing your crazy polytonal and polyrhythmic stuff, Paul is flying over like a beautiful bird, Joe is dancing in and around all these different kinds of rhythms, and that's his role.

MR: You two were I think 13 and 15 when that quartet ended. Does that sound about right? 1967.

DB: Yeah.

CB: Yeah.

MR: And I wondered did you, were you privy to any of the discussions, like hardly any bands ever break-up without some drama. So here you have a group that's basically world famous. What were your observations at that time? Did it make an impression on you as the family, like this thing that you sort of grew up with, with Eugene Wright, this is ending.

DB: Well I think, you know, I could see that there was a lot of stress in my dad trying to keep this band together, you know, like literally like getting everyone to show up and getting everyone to — because after all those years of being on the road there was animosity between people and actually Paul and Dave were always pretty okay, and actually my dad I think with everyone in the group was pretty okay. But within the group there were different sort of stresses. And actually I'd say Gene Wright too, seemed to be very neutral about everything and could hold it together. But there was always a lot of tension between Paul and Joe Morello for instance.

CB: Right from the get-go.

MR: I remember reading that in one of the recent books. Like he said, "If he stays I'm gone."

CB: Right. The first recording session Paul didn't even show up. That was his threat, I'm boycotting. And it was funny because Paul is the guy that brought Joe to Dave's attention because he heard him playing with Marian McPartland. And Joe was like, had his handcuffs on and was playing brushes all night, and he's such a great player. And that's what Paul wanted was another Joe Dodge, another guy who would be no threat to the chemistry of the counterpoint and the beautiful thing that Dave and him had going. Whereas Dave said to himself if we really want to hit like a new plateau, it wouldn't hurt us to have a killer drummer. And so when Dave talked to Joe about joining the group, Joe

kind of said, "Well I don't know if I really want to join your group because I heard you guys playing, you don't let your drummer do anything." And then Dave was sort of like, "Well we don't let him do anything kind of because he can't do anything." You know?

DB: Right, he swings his butt off but he can't —

CB: He can't do anything else.

DB: He's not like a soloist like a Buddy Rich or something.

CB: Right. And so he said, "Well I've got Marian's gig, I don't know if it's worth leaving." And my dad said, "I promise that I'm going to give you a drum solo feature every night if you leave Marian and join our group." And he was probably thinking of leaving Marian anyhow because he was too handcuffed. You know I don't want to imply — Dave and Marian were good friends.

MR: I was going to ask.

CB: I wouldn't think it was like stealing. You know, that kind of thing. So anyhow in the first gig that they did Joe did get the promised solo, and he played his ass off. Paul didn't know, like oh my God it's like the Frankenstein monster of the world's greatest drummer is in my group and I didn't even know it. Fans went crazy and suddenly Paul was being overshadowed and very shortly with that recording session that's when he —

DB: He suddenly wasn't the limelight guy. Now there was a more democratic approach and everyone was involved.

CB: And then Dave as the leader, you know, said, "Hey, Paul, it's like I think you're wrong about this, I think it's the perfect thing for our group to just really expand and break all the barriers. Joe can handle all the polyrhythmic stuff I can throw at him, all the time signatures. You know, he's the cat, man." And so obviously I'm proud of Dave's leadership. You know he was never a guy that like, to my knowledge, ever literally fired anyone. And he wasn't that kind, as far away as you could get from all the Buddy Rich stories you've ever heard you know. But by osmosis the people that weren't right for his group would find their own creative ways to take themselves out of the group, just, you know, it was like a cosmic decision on the player. "I'm going to leave this band, I don't think it's right for me." They're, "Okay." He never said, "You should leave it's not right for you." You know, it was never one of those things.

MR: Did that sort of leadership skill of avoiding conflicts, was he like that as a father? I guess my question was prompted from last night when you were talking to the audience you said people often ask us what was it like to be a Brubeck kid or the Brubeck family. And you said, "Well it's the only family we did so I can't really answer that." But, I was wondering first of all, you must have learned what the word gig meant at an early age. And your friends probably didn't know what the word gig meant. Did it occur to you, or

at what age did it occur to you that my father and my mother are engaged in a business that most people are not.

CB: Well I can say for me, one of my specific early memories is that, as you probably know Dave really messed up his back, broke his back, broke his neck in this diving accident in the late 40s in Hawaii. And so his back was always, you know, just a time bomb waiting to screw up and so he would say like, "I have a concert" and it would be not too far away. And he would just say, "Does anyone want to come with me?" And I remember I liked it and I said, "Yeah I'll come with you." And he said, "But yeah, on the way back from the gig you've got to sit in the back seat and you've got to rub my shoulders to help me be able to drive back." That was like part of the deal. I'd say, "Okay." And then I remember going to the concert and then seeing Dave and Joe and Gene and Paul playing to like a thousand people or fifteen hundred people, whatever it was, and see them going nuts and hear that great music and from a very early age I thought well this is an attractive, wonderful way to lead your life. You know? It's interesting. And of course we know other families where there's great musicians and they had the complete opposite thing, the parents, you know, weren't a model because they weren't in the arts. You know? "What are you crazy? You should be a doctor or a lawyer." You know? And those people would fight against their heritage in order to become musicians. And in our case my parents wouldn't have been disappointed if we weren't musicians. And the other thing people imagine like maybe Dave was there with Iola with whips like Simon Legree like, "You must practice." You know. They weren't like that either. They encouraged us but they weren't disciplinary about it.

DB: Yeah and for me I remember, you know, specific times. Like I went on the road with my dad when he went to Mexico. That was kind of a famous tour. And actually Monk was on that tour and I guess it was a George Wein festival that went all over the place. And just, you know, being in these huge auditoriums and seeing people really going nuts, like literally picking up a row of chairs and smashing them down and you're going whoa. I mean people were really going crazy like it was a soccer game or something. That was the first time I went, "Oh, like these guys are really like big stars" you know. It had never occurred to me of course it was a different kind of mentality in a different country. But the other thing that I — made me recognize the business aspect of it would be you know coming home from school or something and seeing my mom sitting at a desk and going through fan mail and just she constantly worked at stuff. And they answered every bit of mail and sent out records to people. They were very constant, consistent with their you know, keeping the grass roots thing. Because my mom started out, she was actually in a radio station and long ago she kind of figured out the whole Grateful Dead model. You know go to all the radio stations and let them record the group playing, and have them

just, give them the rights to just put it out there and it will take — you know more people will hear the band. She was really business oriented and kind of opened tons of doors. But just seeing her at work like that, that's when I realized the other side of it. I recognized the creative part of it, and that's the attraction. And then you go okay but there is like a lot of work involved in this too. It's just doesn't happen if you're a creative person. You have to be able to go out there and really work for it.

MR: Yeah, and over the years as Dave wrote more and had more LPs out, keeping track of royalties and are we getting a fair-square deal here and all that.

CB: And of course they weren't because they were the artists.

MR: It's a given.

CB: Well I want to back up and say one thing to your earlier question about Dave and the break-up of the group. Like for me, I wasn't super on top of it because at that point I was going to Interlochen Arts Academy. So I knew it was going to happen, and it was predicted, but to give you some insights on that I mean I think really what drove that decision was Dave relentlessly being on tour for, you know, twenty years or something. And the next thing that he really wanted to do was devote himself to writing big orchestral pieces and choral pieces. And you know he gave everyone in the group like a warning of at least a year, maybe a year and a half, maybe two years. And they sort of said, "You're not really going to disband our group," you know, the most successful group. And if you're Paul Desmond, you know Paul had it easy. He was a fantastic player and he could just show up and play beautifully. And Dave and Iola were doing all the work. And in between he could go to Bradley's or Elaine's and, you know, do his happy drinking and hanging out.

DB: They could drag him on to the next plane to the next gig.

CB: And I don't mean he was a raging alcoholic but he just had a lifestyle.

DB: That he adored.

CB: Right he did.

DB: He wouldn't have traded it for anything.

CB: Right. He was like. "Oh my God if you break up the group what am I going to do with my lifestyle?"

DB: I'll have to go to work.

CB: And Joe and Gene — and then right, like my parents always had great admiration for Gene in terms of his personality. Like he was just a guy — Gene was very special not only from his musical point of view but people have to realize that Gene had to deal with being in the quartet and being wildly successful and a little bit parallel to like Jackie Robinson. Other black musicians were giving him crap about, "You're playing with these white guys? Why are you playing with these white guys." You know, "the white guys are

stealing our music" and all that kind of crap. And Gene just handled it with typical diplomacy and grace. I don't know maybe that's how he got the name "Senator."

DB: You know and then also he had to deal with prejudice everywhere, like the tours of the south where they would say, "You can't go on stage with that guy," and you know all that kind of stuff. Dave canceled huge amounts of concerts in the south, I forget how many there were, like 23 concerts or something where when they found out that — because the quartet before they got Gene it was an all-white group.

CB: I think Norman Bates was the bass player.

DB: You know and on Jazz Goes to College and all that. So the image is oh great, it's a white jazz group, that'll fly. So once there was the addition of Gene then you know they weren't so sure they wanted that on stage.

MR: I just read a thing about Cecil Taylor, and I think it was about the Five Spot, and he had related how his quartet got a very small amount of money for playing a week and then the Dave Brubeck Quartet came in and they got three times what he did. And I wonder if Dave was aware of those things. Because I know he would have hated it.

CB: Yeah.

DB: Well he might have been. I mean in terms of that sort of stuff though, he had Joe Glaser, who was, you know, Louis Armstrong's manager. Joe was a very firm business guy. He knew those guys were in demand and he pretty much would take everything to the limit of what he could get from a club owner or whatever. And he kind of knew what those limits were. Whereas I think a lot of times, I know for myself over the years I've called places and usually you never get a call back, you know that whole story. And then it's like, "Well you want to come play? Uh a hundred bucks a man." You know that kind of thing. And I think most people just go, "Oh man I so want to play." But they were in a different position. You know he had been on *Time* magazine. You know. So at that point you take advantage of whatever you can get, and I guess you look at all the other people that got screwed you're making up for it by getting something out of it.

CB: And also to get into your question more precisely I mean it would depend on what year was Cecil Taylor talking about, and how popular was Dave compared to Cecil at that moment. I mean it could be a completely color blind issue. You know Dave had maybe already had "Take Five" as an international hit and probably Cecil Taylor, and I'm just saying that because no one's had a big international hit that you could find on a juke box. Like it wouldn't matter if Cecil Taylor was God himself, that would be the business reality of like if you were the club owner how many —

DB: Yeah, how many people are going to come and see this person?

CB: Oh and speaking of juke boxes I must say another revelatory moment for me is I was on the road going to a concert with Dad in New Jersey and we went to a typical shiny silver

Jersey diner. And then we sat down in the booth and it had one of those juke boxes, you know, where you have pages to flip. And I remember seeing there were Beatle songs and then I saw "Take Five" Dave Brubeck Quartet. Holy God, my dad's made it. He's in a juke box along with the Beach Boys and the Beatles and the Rolling Stones. You know. And by the way that scene is just so beautifully manifested and portrayed in the movie "Pleasantville" when Jeff Daniels plays this soda jerk and it's a movie that's all, everyone's in black and white. They live in this TV land fantasy reality. And it's just everyone is so cardboard, "Hello."

DB: And they're in a diner.

CB: Right they're in a diner and they have a juke box like that and they start playing "Take Five" and they're going like, and you can see their ears start to turn pink and it's like their brains are like — and they end up being in color. And they're going, "What's wrong with me, what's going on" you know it's like, I wish I could talk to that director someday because there it is. It's like Dave thought out of the box. It's a beat. It's not 4/4, it's 5/4. I think one of the reasons "Take Five" was popular is the sort of drone kind of middle-east — or the Indian thing of like a pedal and a modal thing. I think all these things sort of happen to come together. And that just manifests so well. I mean if we had no time, in how much time we could do our video show I'd love to have that scene in our video salute because it says everything.

DB: Yeah and I guess socially the implication is like okay we're going from a drab world to the world's opening up and the colors are opening and Jackson Pollock's throwing paint. And you know the whole thing happened in that time period that really revolutionized the future, and even the acceptance of the Beatles and all that. There was a lot of groundwork that was laid.

CB: Then Dave in his older years would say, "When I look back at it I guess in a way I was kind of a pioneer of world music." You know the stuff that came back from that tour that made it into jazz. And of course he was following the advice of Milhaud saying the same thing about when you travel open your ears, incorporate music you hear in other countries into what you're doing and then you'll be an innovator helping your art form grow.

MR: I've had the privilege of being in the Brubeck house twice to interview your parents. And I was struck, Dave had been working on a piece the day I got there and he took me to the piano and he said come on. It was for piano and voice, and the war in Afghanistan had just started and it was reflective of that. And it was interesting because he said, "Iola said no one will want to sing it. It's too sad." And I got this little picture of their back and forth and her opinions, voicing her opinions about his music, in addition to handling so much of the business. And it was just a neat moment.

CB: Yeah well she was deeply involved in the evolution of all the religious pieces he wrote and there's like 17 or 18 of them where a lot of it would be Bible quotes but you know one of the pieces like "Gates of Justice" is a combination of Old Testament, New Testament, and Martin Luther King. And Dan and I both know that you know like there are so many misconceptions about my dad but one of them is that he wrote all this music that had Biblical text and you might conclude oh he's Jimmy Swaggart that plays jazz piano or something. But as far as he's concerned the Biblical text is just a way to nail everyone for their fake Christian attitudes and the hypocrisy. You know I'm going to point out to you in the Bible where Jesus is pointing out exactly what you're doing that's racist. Or after Kent State, you know I was the age, I was in high school and we did a piece he wrote called "Truth is Fallen." It was like from Isaiah. "Truth is fallen in the streets and equity cannot enter." Like a national guard shot college kids who were just, you know, having a good time and trying to put flowers in their guns. And what the hell is happening in America? But the most powerful way to say that instead of him saying it is quote the Bible and ram it right up there you know. You pretend you're Christians, you know, how would Jesus have handled the situation?

MR: He came to Catholicism fairly late in life, didn't he? I think I read something where someone asked him about it and he said well I didn't come from anything. I don't know if he was an agnostic.

CB: No he wasn't agnostic.

DB: No actually his mother was a Christian Scientist.

CB: Which is a befuddling religion if there ever was one.

DB: Yeah. And his dad was a cowboy and so he had ethics and morality that were very much right down the line of like he would never have done anything that wasn't sort of Biblically correct in a certain way. But it wasn't through a religious following, it was through life experience. You know you don't treat someone like that because it will come back to get you. Or you don't — he had, wouldn't you say that you know he just had this kind of —

CB: Yeah and Judeo-Christian ethical morality thing was strong in his blood. You know? And Grandma Bessie was a Christian Scientist and it was a very wacky religion and Grandpa Pete believed in baked beans, stars, and rattlesnakes. But you combine those two — and you know World War II was a deep experience for my dad and that's when he vowed to himself "I want to get the tools so I can write a huge orchestral choral piece with Biblical text that somehow does this thing about somehow changing hearts and minds so we don't have" — you know I'm talking to you on the eve of maybe another European war right now with Ukraine and Russia and the NATO allies. But he'd gone with Patton's army, seen cities blown up and you know even though he wasn't on D-day beach, you know

like "Saving Private Ryan" and the horror show of that that was portrayed so beautifully or horribly in that movie. You know he still saw plenty of horrible things and met lots of people and met lots of just regular Germans who thought what happened to our country? You know how the hell did this guy Adolf Hitler completely take us and throw us into this horrible thing and we ended up killing millions of people. And they all believe that Christ is their savior. Like how is that happening and they're bombing. You know it's just such a crazy thing. And I want to tell you a story that, you know who Gene Lees is?

MR: Yes.

CB: Gene was doing an interview with Dave and he was asking him how did you get through World War II and what really affected you? And our dad was saying that he had a book he carried in his knapsack and it was sort of like a history of Europe or something, it was a very thick book which would be a funny thing for a trooper to have in his backpack along with an extra pair of boots and some socks. And he said because I kept reading this to find out, to get a sense of if I take myself out of my own lifetime where are we in the great scope of ebb and flow of history and democracy and Authoritarian rule and wars. So they had this deep talk. And Gene was out on the west coast. And they hung up the phone. And a few hours later Gene had written down the title because he said yeah maybe I'll go out and try to find that book, I think that could be an insight into you. And he called Dave up and he said, "Dave, I want to tell you this, this is amazing, I found the book." And my dad said. I mean I wish I could remember the exact title you know, the history of western civilization by so-and-so. And he said, "Well that's amazing." He said, "You don't understand. I found THE book." He went to a used bookstore and it had David Warren Brubeck PFC written in the book. Somehow it had ended up in a used bookstore. Now how's that for a mystery. So anyhow back to, that's why he was breaking up the quartet. I think he had — after being sued and wiped out earlier in his career he had enough money to put us through school, he had enough money from record royalties and stuff that he could really liberate himself from being on the road.

DB: And he wanted to spend more time, you know, with his kids and all that.

MR: I wondered if he was conflicted about missing baseball games and missing birthdays?

DB: Yeah all that kind of stuff, yeah. And actually our second oldest brother had a lot of issues that, you know, he wasn't around to deal with and I think he had a lot of sort of guilt around that. So I think that was a big part of it too, wanting to be able to help him.

CB: But it's also interesting to note, and if I have my history right, that after he broke up the group and their last concert was in Pittsburgh, and I remember being impressed seeing John Chancellor from the NBC Nightly News, that was the button on the national newscast, the Dave Brubeck Quartet gave their last concert tonight. You know it's still of that much importance. And I think that coming summer George Wein said, "You know

Dave, you've never really played with Gerry" — Gerry Mulligan. He lives in Greenwich just down the road. You guys would probably be a potent force you know, if you — and so you know after not being on the road for six months maybe Dave missed it a little more than he thought he would.

DB: Yeah, or maybe he thought, you know with the quartet it was just a constant grind, but that he could pick and choose. Some concerts but —

CB: Everyone's an independent contractor and no one's on salary and you know there's a different sense of obligation.

DB: If George Wein puts it together and pays Gerry and pays him.

MR: Let someone else do that.

CB: Right. And you know Alan Dawson was a brilliant drummer and Jack Six and those guys made some wonderful records together.

DB: Yeah.

CB: So he sort of had his cake and ate it too. He was liberated from doing 150 concerts a year, but he could still play jazz with Gerry and Alan and Jack.

DB: And me as a drummer I was very lucky because Joe was very inspiring you know, it was like oh man I'd love to be able to play like that. But when Alan came along there was someone that could really explain what he was doing. He was just unbelievably brilliant at saying, well tearing things apart and saying, "Well if you want to do that you have to, you know." I learned so much from him, it was crazy you know. Just very quickly, like within a short span of time he just taught me what I hadn't learned all my life it felt like.

MR: Fortunate.

DB: Yeah.

MR: I wanted to ask you something about, I saw an unlikely thing in your house, a Baldwin Exterminator Amplifier.

CB Oh yeah.

DB: Yeah. The excretionator.

MR: Because I played in a band once where the whole band was played through the amp. And to see it in the Brubeck home just like there's a story behind this. Say it again?

DB: Say I wonder what those things are worth. If they're worth anything or —

MR: They are, I looked it up this morning.

DB: You did? Are they worth a fortune?

MR: No, they're not worth a fortune but they're worth something.

CB: Well I know I played a gig with the Los Angeles Jazz Orchestra and we played it in a hall that was named after Karen Carpenter, or Richard Carpenter or something. And when I went out to the lobby to sign autographs and stuff they had, in a glass case, this thing about the Carpenters. And there was one of those small Baldwin amps, like the kind we

had. I mean the reason we had Baldwin was Dave was a Baldwin piano artist and he said, "Hey your kids play rock & roll and stuff," you know, "do you think they would like some amps?" And actually we had them for a while. And actually you know who's got the Exterminator is my son-in-law, who is a carpenter and a drummer. And he's got the Exterminator set up so he can play back CDs so he can bang along with it with Primus or some of these other groups.

MR: I knew there had to be a reason that this thing was in this living room.

CB: Oh you know what? And I never quite — you brought up the question of how did Dave become a Catholic. And it's a very interesting story. So he's always been interested in Jesus and all these different religions. There's times in our lives where Dan, mainly, he was the prime mover like the couple of times we took Dave to meet, you know like an Eastern religious leader like a Baba Muktananda or Baba Hari Dass, or these different people. So yeah, he had an open mind. And you know one of the things I think it was Hari Dass said, and you can correct me, Dan, if I'm wrong. But you know there's many paths to seek enlightenment but his analogy which always made a hell of a lot of sense to me is you can keep exploring this and exploring that and exploring this. But if you ever want to get up to the mountaintop of whatever path you choose religiously you've got to stick with one or you'll just keep jumping and jumping and never get anywhere. So when Dave wrote his beautiful mass called "To Hope" he left out — for some weird reason because it's a very structured thing what goes into a concert mass, from hundreds of years of tradition in Catholic church music — he left out the "Our Father." And one morning he — it's a beautiful, beautiful — if you hear it, it's gorgeous and it just sounds like it couldn't be written any other way, like each note deserves to follow the next. You know it's just one of those that fell out of the sky perfect. And he dreamed that. And it was one of those dreams where he went, "Oh I'm dreaming. I want to write that down before I forget." So he wrote it down. And it's beautiful, it went to the mass. And for Dave the final straw for making him commit to one religion to get to enlightenment was he thought well God showed me and gave me that piece. And that was it.

MR: Wow. That reminds me of a story both Dave and Iola told me about being in a van like a VW type van driving up to summer camp in Vermont, music camp. And that's when "God's Love Made Visible" was written.

CB: Oh yeah. Probably driving Matthew to Kinhaven.

MR: I think you're right. That's what he said. And Dave said, "I'm done with this" and she said, "No you're not." And I'll have to show you, like I'm telling you a story about your father that you don't know I guess. And then he went up and got up there and they were put up in an A frame and up in the top attic were all the Christmas decorations so he went up there and finished it. It's just very touching.

CB: Dan and I have often played that piece with our dad called "La Fiesta de la Posada." And it usually would happen in December, these performances. And God, Christmas has gotten so just pukingly commercialized. I was trying to think of a worse word than disgustingly and I came up with that one. I don't know if it's a real word. But you would get the real sense of Christmas and love when you do this piece, "La Fiesta de la Posada" 'cause it has a chorus, which is usually like town folk that like singing you know. And that's a whole different thing. You know it's almost Communistic. It's not professional singers usually, it's just people that love singing, it's an expression of their spirit. And if there's a children's choir in it, and there's a Mary and there's three wise men. I mean we've done it in Durango, Colorado where they had Mary — they had a live donkey bringing Mary in.

DB: That was a questionable donkey.

CB: Yeah well the donkey relieved himself on the way up to the stage. And you know the three wise men, you know it's funny 'cause like if you just put on your funny hat, they've got sombreros, it looks like the Three Amigos. But it's in the reflective of the real tradition of "La Fiesta de la Posada" is about, it's amazing what survived in the Bible, that you have you know Joseph and Mary, they're not rich, they're really poor, they're refugees. That's all set up, you know at least we have an open heart and kindness. Who knows what's going to come out of a refugee? I mean look at Obama in a way. Well not that his parents were refugees but —

DB: He was born in a different country though. We all know that.

CB: No, but I mean he didn't come from a classic mother-father "Leave it to Beaver" background. It's like just that that potential is all there. And I just wrote a piece that Dan and Darius played on their premier called "Mary Magdalene and the Garden Dweller" and I was hired specifically to write a piece in the style of Dave with jazz and also chorus and orchestra. And one of the things that amazes me is if you look at how nuns don't have the powers of priests, and you know the church has always been so patriarchal. But it's amazing that despite all that and despite all these filthy old bishops and abbots and probably popes that wanted to white-wash it, that Mary Magdalene is this powerful person who had more courage than all the disciples. When they're all quivering in their boots hiding in an attic she's the one that sees Jesus as a garden dweller and says, "Listen you chicken shits, get out there and spread the Gospel." And it's amazing that that part has survived. How did that happen with all this? And maybe that part's divine that despite all — there must have been a huge conspiracy to get rid of that stuff. That empowered women you know. But it's there still in the Bible.

MR: That's some heavy stuff.

CB: Sorry.

MR: I like it.

CB: That's the kind of stuff you know where you have Dave and Iola for parents you end up thinking about.

MR: Yeah. That's what I was trying to — I couldn't fashion a question because to outside observers they both seem like incredible role models. I don't know if their children think of their parents as role models?

CB: Yeah we do. I mean all of us have deep respect for our parents and all of us have deep respect for the luck we have of being born into this family you know?

MR: Now my wife and I were blessed with two daughters who hardly ever gave us many problems but we did have a time out chair. And I wonder if you had —

CB: Did it have the famous artwork on it?

MR: It wasn't that fancy. Was there a disciplinary modus operandi with your parents?

CB: When we were little kids there was an infamous mythological belt called the "wapper dapper" —

DB: That we never saw but we heard about it.

CB: Yeah. If you get out of line, you know, "I'm going to have to take out the "wapper dapper" which was — as far as we could figure it was like a big-ass cowboy belt, that maybe had some of those little silver dollar buffalo things left in them so it would hurt extra hard. But and certainly our Grandma Myrtle — I still remember back, this relates directly. When they were gone a long time on that tour in '58 Grandma Myrtle as the name might imply was a tall, just completely straight ahead kind of person, like the famous painting that you see on the Corn Flakes box. She would make that lady look like a complete roaring 20s floozy. She was just a stiff straight ahead person. And so I did something wrong and she, being of a previous generation, said, "I'm going to give you a spanking." And I can't even remember what I did wrong. But I remember like I'm always the clever one, I put a Dr. Suess book in the back of my pants so when she spanked me it wouldn't hurt as much. And of course she never noticed. The book was removed and I got double the spanking. Because she stayed with us for a couple of months while Mom and Darius and Michael were with Dave on that famous Middle Eastern tour.

MR: Was there sibling rivalry on and off? I guess musically is my question but maybe with other things?

CB: I don't think so so much. We were mainly harmoniously playing together at different things. And sometimes we'd temporarily pull in the same direction and then pull in different directions.

MR: Now I don't want to read anything into this, but you both have had your own groups and continue to, and like most musicians you wear many hats to create. The music you do

when you lead your own groups, do you think you've made a conscious or unconscious decision to sort of separate it from the Brubeck heritage?

DB: Well in my group there is the bass player in the group is a singer. And actually the way it happened — very organically because I was playing gigs around Vancouver and I you know was using different people. And someone said, "Oh you should try this bass player." So this guy Adam Thomas came and played on a gig and he was a great bass player and upright bass. And a couple of gigs in you know when I called him for this and that I called, I think I called "In Your Own Sweet Way" and said, "Do you want me to sing it?" And I was like well this could be horrible or it could be great but there's, whatever, 30 people out there. Who cares? Just sure, go ahead, sing it. And he just sounded great singing it. And I realized that no one had ever done — taken my mom's lyrics and you know put together everything — or it wouldn't be everything but put together like we did a double album where it was all lyrics that my mom had written and songs my dad had written. My mom wrote the lyrics for the tunes my dad wrote. And you know no one had really done that before. So I thought this is a good vehicle to try it. But as far as in that group we often, prior to that project we would just play all kinds of tunes and just you know pick tunes that we liked playing, like you would on a normal jazz gig. So I don't know that's a weird way of explaining it but that was the one thing that gave us a direction. And then that kind of took off and we actually got nominated for a Juno and all we literally did was record a concert we did at The Cellar in Vancouver and put it out. And mostly because I wanted those tunes recorded. And it got picked up by the Juno people and they were like this is amazing. So we almost won a Juno. We were in the last three of best jazz records.

CB: You know you should go back further and talk about the Dolphins.

DB: Well yeah I mean I've had different groups.

MR: Which I heard in Utica.

DB : Oh you did? Huh in Utica. Yeah. I'm trying to remember the club.

MR: Tiny's.

DB: Tiny's there we go. Yeah in that group, Mike was in that group too, the guitar player that played last night. And that was an interesting band because you know it was like a far cry away from anything I had really done. So I had to kind of discipline myself to really play parts. And there was a lot of complicated music in that.

CB: Yeah. The arrangements were crazy.

DB: Yeah just ridiculous arrangements and very tight. And all the records we did were with DMP and that was live to two track. So when you hear those records I think the most amazing thing is to know that it's all live. You know there was no overdubbing, none of that stuff, and to have gotten that on record, as complicated as that music was. I guess the

only thing that was ever harder is we did some Larry Coryell recordings and that was direct to disc where they put a vinyl thing, they heat it up, they stick it on, they put a thing and they —

MR: Like the old days.

CB: It goes literally right into the vinyl. And in fact two studios in Nashville were involved. So there was two side-by-side studios. See there are so many studios and one was like half a block from the other and the thing is going on.

DB: Yeah but that's crazy because you have to do a whole half of a record.

CB: Yeah it's not a tune at a time, it's a whole side of a record at a time.

DB: And so if you made a mistake it's like ugh, you've got to go back and the guy's got to heat up the vinyl you know. That process was terrible.

CB: There's a funny story that goes with that which is, and they're actually really good records, but Darius had written a song called "The Midnight Sailor." And that was the one that was the worst. Where it was never our fault, it was like one time a cop car went down the alley between the two. And like in the take it was like [speaks loudly as if with megaphone] "we've got a ten four five…" you know it was like oh, no. And it was 18 minutes into a beautiful performance of three tunes on one side. So that got scrapped. And another time like, "Oh we got a bump in the vinyl we've got to start again." And each time this would happen Larry would, we'd take a break while they reset everything and he'd have another beer. So we're finally into the fifth attempt at doing this whole side. And at that point when it comes to Larry's guitar solo — he was very inventive — out comes the beer bottle and it's become like a slide guitar thing with a Heineken beer bottle. And you could hear it to this day on that record. And it actually sounds kind of great.

MR: I'm glad you mentioned Darius because there's this wonderful picture in the recent book about your father, *A Life in Time* and you three are standing behind your parents and it struck me, it looks, it's the time of the era. It looks like Dave and Iola go to Haight Asbury. Because you all had really long hair and it just is so terrific to see that combination of the generations. And I'm not even sure what I'm trying to say except it's a great pic.

CB: Well it is funny, like because at that point Gerry Mulligan had really long hair and a beard and would wear bell bottoms and stuff and I think Maynard Ferguson. I mean I think there was a lot of establishment jazz guys, instead of fighting it just started going with the flow. Hey, and to your previous question, we were talking about Dan's groups, I just wanted to say that when I was coming out of Interlochen I met all these young very good classical musicians that also loved rock & roll. And we had school bands and we said hey when we graduate we're going to make a demo tape and see if we can get a deal.

And I very consciously knew that Dave was this really popular figure in jazz and I couldn't compete in that world but I really wanted to have a really really creative rock & roll band. And the first thing we did was the group was called The New Heavenly Blue. We did a record on RCA. And then we did a record on Atlantic. And that evolved into a group called Sky King that we did a record on Columbia. And Madcat, the great harmonica player who I still play with and who played with two generations of Brubeck, he was in that band. And the Sky King thing was really quite cool but the legendary guitarist Steve Cropper produced us and we brought in the Tower of Power horns. At one point we were cutting our second record and the producer was Randy Brecker because they had just did the Brecker Brothers record with Skunk Funk and I could convince Bruce Lundvall — that's one of the best produced records ever. If we have to have a producer let's bring this guy in and then Bob James got involved and then Randy said, "Hey I want to bring in my friend" you know, "he's a great background guy, and we'll bring in a singer." So it was like Whitney Houston's mother Cissy Houston and some other amazing —

DB: Mike Brecker played on that.

CB: Right. And Jerry Bergonzi and also the background singer coach was this guy named Luther, Luther Vandross. And that record never even came out because the guy that was head of Columbia A&R, Mickey Eichner, was a complete idiot. I hope he hears this someday — oh he's probably gone. But he was totally threatened to have Bob James on Tappan Zee Records come into the Columbia label fold. So just by bad luck the first project he could kill to show Bob James who had more power, it was our record. So despite it being ready to go and us touring the country and on radio stations saying, "We're playing tracks from our new record" it didn't happen. And so like half the guys in that group just quit the music business they were so demoralized. There's a long story about lawyers selling us out and getting rewarded and all this kind of stuff. And my dad said, "Oh Chris, don't be blue about that stuff" you know, "why don't you just start playing bass with me?" So I did.

MR: Not a bad solution to that problem.

CB: Yeah.

MR: That's great. Well I've just enjoyed so much talking to you both. And it's hard to imagine that Dave passed away just about ten years ago.

DB: That's really hard to imagine that it's been ten years. Crazy.

MR: I'm pleased to hear that the library in Wilton is becoming or has become a home for —

DB: The archives.

MR: The archives, yeah.

CB: Yeah. We were really thrilled that, and surprised, that at a time when he may have had a vote that could save democracy in America he — that was canceled for a couple of days so he came up and Richard Blumenthal did the ribbon cutting. Our state senator. And when we met him I just, you know, you don't know what his background is. The first thing he says, he says, "We grew up in a classical household" the Blumenthal household, "and my brother and I, our big rebellion is we'd go out and buy your dad's records." So I knew like Obama and Clinton, you know we had someone that actually got it, that was glad to be there. And that was a wonderful thing.

MR: Well the fact that you're doing this and you have the Brubeck News going on, which I just read this morning, it's terrific and I thank you for doing it. It's really important. And even though it was delayed for a year and a half I guess, it's all good.

DB: Yeah, it's coming back.

CB: It is all good and I've got to say that like the manifestation of that Brubeck News thing that you read wouldn't happen if it weren't for my wife working tirelessly on this. You know she was very close to Dave and Iola and she helped them with a lot of stuff, and that's sort of what she does — a lot to keep us going too so I'm very grateful for that.

MR: Well I'm going to send you out into a snowstorm I guess from the sounds of things. But I wish you safe travels and continued success.

CB: Yeah, and thank you and I think that what you're doing up here is so important. You know it's like my next birthday I'm going to be 70 so I have to be a little bit realistic even though I feel like I'm still a 13-year-old kid that loves music.

MR: With a Baldwin Exterminator.

CB: Yeah, right. The Exterminator might come and visit me, the Grim Exterminator.

DB: The Grim Exterminator.

CB: It looks like our refrigerator and he's got his scythe you know. And so someday hopefully people will be looking at this laughing and like wow, this is semi-interesting.

MR: Well good. I'll see you on the flip side.

CB: Okay.

MR: Thanks a lot.

CB: Well thank you.